Research Timeline Planning Template

Introduction to Timeline Planning

A realistic research timeline is essential for project success. This template helps you plan, track, and manage your research activities from proposal to completion.

BASIC TIMELINE TEMPLATE

For Undergraduate Thesis (3-6 Months)

Month	Weeks	Phase	Activities	Deliverables
1	1-4	Planning	• Topic selection • Initial literature review • Consult supervisor • Refine research questions	• Topic approved • Preliminary bibliography
2	5-8	Proposal	• Literature review • Methodology design • Write proposal • Ethics application	• Complete proposal draft • Ethics submitted
3	9-12	Preparation	• Revise proposal • Develop instruments • Pilot testing • Proposal defense	• Approved proposal • Data collection tools ready
4	13-16	Data Collection	• Recruit participants • Collect data • Organize data • Ongoing analysis	• Complete dataset • Field notes
5	17-20	Analysis	• Data analysis • Create tables/figures • Interpret findings • Start writing	• Analysis complete • Results chapter draft
6	21-24	Writing & Defense	• Complete all chapters • Revisions • Format references • Prepare presentation • Defense	• Final thesis • Successful defense

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For Master's Thesis (12-18 Months)

Phase	Duration	Key Activities
1. Topic Development	Months 1-2	• Extensive literature review • Identify research gap • Define research questions • Form advisory committee
2. Proposal Development	Months 3-4	• Comprehensive lit review • Detailed methodology • Theoretical framework • Write proposal chapters
3. Proposal Defense	Month 5	• Revise proposal • Prepare presentation • Defend proposal • Address committee feedback

Phase	Duration	Key Activities
4. Ethics & Preparation	Month 6	• Ethics approval • Develop instruments • Pilot study • Refine methods
5. Data Collection	Months 7-10	• Recruit participants • Systematic data collection • Document procedures • Preliminary analysis
6. Data Analysis	Months 11-13	• Full data analysis • Statistical tests • Theme development • Create visuals
7. Writing	Months 14-16	• Write all chapters • Multiple revisions • Committee feedback • Format document
8. Final Defense	Months 17-18	• Final revisions • Presentation prep • Defense • Final corrections

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For PhD Dissertation (3-5 Years)

Year	Key Milestones
Year 1	• Coursework • Comprehensive literature review • Form dissertation committee • Preliminary research
Year 2	• Complete coursework • Comprehensive exams • Proposal development • Proposal defense
Year 3	• Primary data collection • Ongoing analysis • Conference presentations • Publication drafts
Year 4	• Complete data collection • Full analysis • Write chapters 4-5 • Revise chapters 1-3
Year 5	• Complete writing • Committee revisions • Final defense • Submit for graduation

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DETAILED WEEKLY TIMELINE EXAMPLE

24-Week Undergraduate Thesis Timeline

Phase 1: Planning (Weeks 1-4)

Week 1:

- [ ] Meet with supervisor to discuss interests
- [ ] Brainstorm 3-5 potential topics
- [ ] Conduct preliminary literature search
- [ ] Submit topic ideas to supervisor

Week 2:

- [ ] Receive topic feedback

- [ ] Select final topic
- [ ] Create research question outline
- [ ] Begin systematic literature search

Week 3:

- [ ] Read 10-15 key articles
- [ ] Create annotated bibliography
- [ ] Draft preliminary research questions
- [ ] Outline potential methodology

Week 4:

- [ ] Meet supervisor to finalize topic
- [ ] Refine research questions
- [ ] Identify variables/concepts
- [ ] Plan proposal structure

Phase 2: Proposal Writing (Weeks 5-8)

Week 5:

- [ ] Write Introduction chapter
- [ ] Draft problem statement
- [ ] State objectives
- [ ] Justify significance

Week 6:

- [ ] Write Literature Review
- [ ] Synthesize sources thematically
- [ ] Identify research gap
- [ ] Develop conceptual framework

Week 7:

- [ ] Write Methodology chapter
- [ ] Describe research design
- [ ] Detail sampling strategy
- [ ] Explain data collection methods

Week 8:

- [ ] Complete proposal draft
- [ ] Write abstract
- [ ] Format references
- [ ] Submit to supervisor for review

Phase 3: Proposal Revision & Preparation (Weeks 9-12)

Week 9:

- [ ] Receive supervisor feedback
- [ ] Major revisions to proposal
- [ ] Strengthen weak sections
- [ ] Submit ethics application

Week 10:

- [ ] Design data collection instruments
- [ ] Create survey/interview questions
- [ ] Develop coding schemes
- [ ] Prepare materials

Week 11:

- [ ] Pilot test instruments (5-10 people)
- [ ] Analyze pilot feedback
- [ ] Revise instruments
- [ ] Finalize procedures

Week 12:

- [ ] Proposal defense preparation
- [ ] Create presentation slides
- [ ] Practice presentation
- [ ] Defend proposal

Phase 4: Data Collection (Weeks 13-16)

Week 13:

- [ ] Finalize ethics approval
- [ ] Recruit participants

- [ ] Schedule data collection sessions
- [ ] Prepare materials

Week 14-15:

- [ ] Conduct interviews/surveys
- [ ] Organize data daily
- [ ] Take field notes
- [ ] Track participation rates

Week 16:

- [ ] Complete data collection
- [ ] Verify data completeness
- [ ] Transcribe recordings (if applicable)
- [ ] Organize files

Phase 5: Data Analysis (Weeks 17-20)

Week 17:

- [ ] Clean and prepare data
- [ ] Enter data into software
- [ ] Check for errors
- [ ] Run descriptive statistics

Week 18:

- [ ] Conduct main analyses
- [ ] Create tables and figures
- [ ] Identify key patterns
- [ ] Take analytical notes

Week 19:

- [ ] Complete all analyses
- [ ] Verify calculations
- [ ] Interpret findings
- [ ] Begin Results chapter

Week 20:

- [ ] Finish Results chapter
- [ ] Write findings clearly
- [ ] Create professional tables/figures
- [ ] Start Discussion chapter

Phase 6: Writing & Finalization (Weeks 21-24)

Week 21:

- [ ] Write Discussion chapter
- [ ] Interpret results
- [ ] Connect to literature
- [ ] Discuss implications

Week 22:

- [ ] Write Conclusion chapter
- [ ] Summarize findings
- [ ] State limitations
- [ ] Suggest future research
- [ ] Write Abstract

Week 23:

- [ ] Complete full draft
- [ ] Check all references
- [ ] Format document
- [ ] Submit to supervisor

Week 24:

- [ ] Make final revisions
- [ ] Proofread thoroughly
- [ ] Prepare defense presentation
- [ ] Final submission and defense

GANTT CHART TEMPLATE

Activity/Week 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24

Topic Selection
Lit Review
Proposal
Ethics
Instrument Dev